The forest was thick with oaks, and she brushed past their rough trunks, scraping her arms and legs. Her muscles ached.

Katya cried, and she did her best to hush her. After a while, maybe an hour, when Léa felt she was deep inside the forest, she stopped and listened for footfalls, voices, the metallic clunk of a gun. All she heard were softer sounds: birds hopping from the tree to the ground and the wind rustling the catkins hanging from the branches. She was alone, not safe—she would never feel that again—but not in immediate danger.

She gently put Katya on the forest floor. The baby was covered in blood, as was Léa. Josef's blood. André's too. She needed to be alone. Moving away from Katya, she walked as if she might walk into another life. Then she collapsed on the ground.

In her heart, she screamed and howled at all that had been lost: Josef, André, and earlier, Rose. All gone. A primal fear held her back from calling out. She didn't know who or what else awaited her. Three shots she'd never seen coming had torn her life to shreds. Who were those men? Why did they have to kill so swiftly without saying a single word? None of it made sense. Her hands were still shaking from the shock. Fearing other men like them were nearby, she had to be small and quiet. Rolling on her side, she curled up in a ball and closed her eyes.

Josef, she whispered, sinking her fingers into the forest floor. The ache inside grew. Why had the man with the Karabiner let her live?

Katya whimpered.

Léa rolled over on her back, staring at the canopy, the pale green, soft new leaves in bunches, and beyond, the bitter gray sky. She was tired and weary, like a soldier after battle. A voice inside told her to get up and move. But she'd lost all strength. Wouldn't it be easier if she stayed on the ground, letting her body sink back into the earth? Disappear. Everyone she loved was gone. What was there worth fighting for? One day she too would die. Why not now?

Katya cried.

She turned and sat up, looking out over the undergrowth. Two tiny fists reached out in the air, trying to find something to hold on to. Léa drew her knees up and rested her head on them. She couldn't go on. It was too much. Where was Rose? She'd lost Rose and Josef on the same day. The two people who had known her the best. She lifted her head and saw the blood